

ChiEAC Professional Development & Job Search Protocol

Purpose

The purpose of this opportunity is not simply to complete a project or submit job applications. The goal is to help you develop the habits, professional network, portfolio, and discipline necessary to secure long-term employment in your field. You should approach this experience as if it were a full-time professional role.

LinkedIn Networking Strategy

Monday: Networking Day

Connection Requests

Every Monday, send the maximum number of LinkedIn connection requests permitted by the platform.

Prioritize

Connect with:

- Hiring managers
- Team leads
- Directors
- Recruiters
- Senior professionals in your field
- Alumni from your university
- Professionals working at organizations where you would like to work

Avoid

Do not send connection requests to:

- Profiles displaying Blue or Green Open-to-Work/Hiring halos
- Profiles without a professional photograph
- Profiles that appear inactive
- Obvious salespeople, coaches, or recruiters selling services

Your goal is to build a network of professionals who are currently employed and actively working in your target industry.

Connection Request Mindset

Do not ask for jobs. Do not ask for referrals. Do not ask for meetings. Your first objective is simply to establish professional relationships. You are not desperate...you just need a little attention. By sharing out the work you are doing and building a narrative on LinkedIn with your posts, this attention will come naturally.

Sunday: Relationship Building Day

Every Sunday, review all connection requests that were accepted during the week. Send a brief message to every new connection to begin conversations with potential connections.

Suggested Message

Good morning, [NAME] 🕶️ Thank you for accepting my connection request. I am looking forward to learning from following your work and insights on LinkedIn. If there is something I can do for you, please let me know. Stay safe and keep in touch. [YOUR NAME]

THAT IS IT...NOTHING MORE THAN THAT...NEVER START ANOTHER MESSAGE WITH “I hope this finds you well” because NOBODY cares.

Important

Keep messages:

- Brief
- Semi-Professional
- Authentic...NEVER FAKE
- Non-transactional...you are NOT trying to sell yourself here

Your goal is to start relationships, not immediately ask for help. Keep it light and keep it casual. Once communication begins, invite these people to join you for an activity that YOU enjoy doing...NEVER INVITE THEM FOR COFFEE or TEA because they already have that at the office and they are more than likely overcaffeinated already!

Communication Rules

Monday

- Send connection requests only.

Sunday

- Reply to all accepted connections.
- Respond to any LinkedIn messages received during the week.

Tuesday through Saturday

- Do not spend significant time networking on LinkedIn...MEET PEOPLE IN PERSON whenever possible.
- Focus on project development and professional growth activities.

Professional Portfolio Project

Project Requirement

Participation in our program requires completion of a professional project. Your project will serve as evidence of your skills, initiative, and ability to create value...it will also be used to help draw attention to you from potential employers. It is critical that you are taking the time to build something that is meaningful and relevant to your industry domain that you can share on your resume. Yes, this opportunity is driven by the philosophy that you do NOT need extra work to do while you are finding a job...it is also driven by the philosophy that EVERYTHING YOU HAVE BEEN DOING UP TO THIS POINT has brought you nothing but rejection...and you need a new strategy.

Project Selection and Development

Your project must:

- Align with the role you want in the next 6–12 months.
- Strengthen a skill you are actively developing...NOTHING that you have already done before
- Demonstrate future career potential...and it MUST be an E2E project resulting in a LIVE URL that you can share.
- Be relevant to current industry hiring trends in the next 6-months...STAY RELEVANT.

Your project should NOT simply replicate your previous work experience. Our purpose working together is to demonstrate your growth and future capability as an expert in your field of work. We do this by facilitating the opportunity that you need to build a portfolio of work that is strong, relevant, and attractive to potential employers.

Project Proposal

Before beginning work, we will work together to build a project that is specifically designed to meet your needs. We will work together to refine the project scope. We will need the following information to begin this process:

- A current resume and brief discussion of your desired career path
- A short project concept with ALL technologies or skills you want to strengthen

Public Portfolio Requirement

Every project must produce a publicly accessible deliverable such as:

- Website
- Dashboard
- Application
- Research Report
- Data Visualization Platform
- Technical Documentation Site

NOTE: You are welcome to add anything to a GitHub site of your own...and a GitHub repository DOES NOT count toward our needs for documentation of work you have completed.

At project completion, you must be able to share a URL with:

- Employers
- Recruiters
- Professional contacts
- ChiEAC leadership

Daily Progress Documentation

LinkedIn Professional Journal

Every day that you work on your project, publish a brief progress update on LinkedIn. Think of LinkedIn as your professional work journal. You are literally using this platform to build a narrative around the work you are doing.

Your updates can include:

- What you built
- Problems solved
- Lessons learned
- Screenshots
- Visualizations
- Technical discoveries
- Project milestones

Tagging Requirement

Every project update should include Chicago Education Advocacy Cooperative (ChiEAC)

This allows us to:

- Repost your work
- Share your progress
- Expand your visibility
- Introduce your work to employers and supporters

Daily Documentation Goal

Every member of this team is expected to create a narrative on their LinkedIn profile that documents the work they are doing to build their skills, their project, and connections they are making. We expect to see screenshots, updates on applications, photos of people you are meeting with, and anything else relevant to your job search. By the end of the project, employers should be able to see:

- Consistency and Growth
- Problem-solving ability
- Communication skills and Professional discipline

Work Schedule Expectations

Establish a Professional Workday

Create a consistent schedule that mirrors the role you are seeking.

Examples:

- 8:00 AM – 4:00 PM
- 9:00 AM – 5:00 PM

Maintain the same schedule each weekday and each week. You NEED A STRUCTURED FORMAT for your professional life that you currently do not possess. You are working to condition your body and mind into a stable routine that is structured and is equivalent to what you can expect when you transition into your paid role.

Work Environment

Do not remain at home. You need to leave your house every day and find a place in public where you can work. The goal is to build professional routines and habits. We do this to ensure that YOU ARE PREPARED to shift into a paid role when the time comes. Below are a few examples of places you can work:

- Work from a library
- Coworking space
- University campus
- Coffee shop
- Community workspace

NTOE: If you are in Chicago, you are welcome to use our facilities in Hyde Park. Call or email Dr. Benjamin Drury to schedule days/times, as needed.

Professional Routine

Treat each day as a workday with the objective of creating the behavioral patterns expected in professional employment. If you spend your entire day at home, you will develop a mindset that is centered on working in a place where work is not designed or intended to enter. Your home is your safe and sacred space of rest. Do NOT disturb your sanctuary.

Recommended routine:

- Wake up early
- Shower
- Dress professionally
- Leave the house
- Arrive at your workspace on time
- Work according to your schedule

Boundaries

When your workday ends:

- Stop working
- Leave the project alone
- Recharge
- Spend time with family and friends
- Exercise
- Rest

Do not work evenings. Do not work weekends. Sustainable performance is more valuable than constant activity.

Job Search Strategy

Stop Mass Applying

Do not spend hours submitting applications to positions where: (a) Nobody knows you; (b) Nobody invited you to apply; (c) You have no organizational connection. Our approach produces low return on high investment of time, energy, and other valuable resources. It is the dedicated goal of our working relationship to help you find a job, and your current strategy of firing off applications into the ether is NOT effective...and you NEED A NEW STRATEGY. So, use ours..and you will find a job in under 6-months.

Relationship-Driven Applications

Focus on organizations where you have:

- A professional contact
- An alumnus connection
- A networking relationship
- A hiring manager connection
- A former colleague connection

Whenever possible:

1. Build the relationship first.
2. Learn about the organization.
3. Express genuine interest.
4. Submit the application.
5. Notify your connection after applying.

Quality Over Quantity

A focused strategy of: (a) 5 meaningful relationships; (b) 5 targeted applications; (c) 5 personalized conversations is FAR more effective than: 100 anonymous applications to positions that you have no connections.

Weekly Accountability Expectations

We are accountable to USCIS to report on the work you are doing. Although we do not have a formal expectation for reporting EVERYTHING you are doing – beyond the project work – you could be called on to share evidence of the following. Every week, be prepared to report:

Networking

- Number of connection requests sent
- Number of accepted connections and number of conversations initiated

Project Progress – COMPLETE THIS FORM EVERY WEEK <https://forms.gle/SwmSeG3ar7A1132s0H>

- Accomplishments completed
- Challenges encountered
- Lessons learned
- Upcoming milestones

Career Development

- Roles being targeted
- Organizations being researched
- Professional skills being strengthened

Job Search

- Applications submitted
- Networking conversations completed
- Interviews scheduled
- Follow-up actions required

Guiding Principle

Your goal is not to look busy. Your goal is to become the type of professional that employers want to hire. Every networking conversation, project milestone, LinkedIn post, and workday should move you one step closer to becoming an obvious choice for the role you want next.